

Author guidelines for IBR, JWB, and APJM compared

All three top international business journals use double-blind review and require a separate title page, but they diverge sharply on word limits, abstract length, reference formatting at submission, and highlights policy. The most operationally critical differences: APJM enforces a hard **10,000-word cap** (all-inclusive), [Springer](https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines) [springer] (https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines) JWB requires **APA 7th edition** citations from the outset, and IBR will desk-reject manuscripts with a **similarity score at or above 25%**. [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/international-business-review/publish/guide-for-authors) Getting these details wrong is the fastest path to a desk rejection. Below is a complete specification for each journal, drawn directly from official guide-for-authors pages.

Quick-reference comparison table

Requirement	IBR (Elsevier)	JWB (Elsevier)	APJM (Springer)
Word limit	Not explicitly stated	Not explicitly stated	10,000 words (incl. footnotes, references, tables, figures)
Abstract	Unstructured, ≤ 150 words	Unstructured, ≤ 250 words	Unstructured, 150–250 words
Reference style	Any consistent style at submission; journal style applied at proof	APA 7th edition	APA 7th edition
Keywords	Max 10 (editors recommend 5–6)	1–7	4–6
Highlights	Required — 3–5 bullets, ≤ 85 chars each	Encouraged — 3–5 bullets, ≤ 85 chars each	Not required
Font / spacing	Not specified ("Your Paper Your Way")	Not specified	10-pt Times Roman (double-spacing expected)
Title page	Separate file	Separate file	Separate file
Review type	Double anonymized	Double anonymized	Double-blind
Submission portal	Editorial Manager	Editorial Manager	Editorial Manager (transitioning to SNAPP)
File format	.doc/.docx or .tex — no PDF	.doc/.docx or .tex — no PDF	.docx/.doc or LaTeX
Data availability	Encouraged	Encouraged	Required for all original research

International Business Review: flexible format, strict anonymization

IBR follows Elsevier's "Your Paper Your Way" philosophy at initial submission, meaning there are **no strict requirements for font, spacing, margins, or reference formatting** — as long as the style is internally consistent. [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/international-business-

review/publish/guide-for-authors) [ScienceDirect]

(<https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/structures/publish/guide-for-authors>) This permissiveness disappears at revision, when authors must supply editable source files in single-column Word format (.doc/.docx) or LaTeX. [ScienceDirect](<https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/structures/publish/guide-for-authors>) ****PDF is never acceptable as a source file.**** [ScienceDirect +2]
(<https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/international-business-review/publish/guide-for-authors>)

The abstract must be ****concise, unstructured, and capped at 150 words**** [ScienceDirect]
(<https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/international-business-review/publish/guide-for-authors>)
[ScienceDirect](<https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/international-business-review/about/information-for-authors/international-business-review-information-for-authors>) – notably shorter than its Elsevier sibling JWB. The guide formally allows up to ****10 keywords****, but the editorial team explicitly advises submitting only ****5–6 well-chosen keywords****, warning that "poor keywords are vague and general" and providing examples of what to avoid ("international business," "qualitative research").

****Highlights are mandatory****, not optional. They must be submitted as a separate editable file named with "Highlights" in the filename, containing ****3–5 bullet points of no more than 85 characters each**** (including spaces). [ScienceDirect](<https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/international-business-review/publish/guide-for-authors>) [ScienceDirect](<https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/journal-of-world-business/publish/guide-for-authors>) A graphical abstract is optional but encouraged.

IBR's anonymization protocol is detailed and strict. Authors must submit a ****separate title page**** containing the title, author names, affiliations, acknowledgments, declaration of interest, and corresponding author's full contact details. [ScienceDirect]
(<https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/international-business-review/publish/guide-for-authors>) The anonymized manuscript file must contain none of this information. [ScienceDirect]
(<https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/international-business-review/publish/guide-for-authors>)
[ScienceDirect](<https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/journal-of-world-business/publish/guide-for-authors>) Self-citations must appear as "[Anonymous, 2007]" with a placeholder reference list entry reading "Details omitted for double-anonymized reviewing." [Elsevier]
(<https://www.elsevier.support/publishing/answer/what-are-the-requirements-for-double-anonymized-peer-review>) Even ****file names and document metadata properties**** must be scrubbed of identifying information. [Elsevier](<https://www.elsevier.com/reviewer/what-is-peer-review/guidelines>)

Two IBR-specific policies stand out. First, all submissions undergo a ****similarity check, and a score of 25% or higher triggers automatic rejection**** – this includes self-plagiarism from authors' own prior publications. [ScienceDirect](<https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/international-business-review/publish/guide-for-authors>) Second, manuscripts must be ****human-authored****: generative AI tools like ChatGPT may not produce manuscript text, though limited use for translation, grammar checking, and data collection is permitted. Any AI use must be disclosed in the cover letter. [ScienceDirect]
(<https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/international-business-review/about/information-for-authors/international-business-review-information-for-authors>)

Sections must be **numbered** (1, 1.1, 1.1.1, etc.), excluding the abstract. [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/international-business-review/publish/guide-for-authors) For figures, IBR requires minimum **300 dpi** for photographs, **500 dpi** for combination artwork, and **1,000 dpi** for line drawings, [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/journal-of-world-business/publish/guide-for-authors) in TIFF, JPEG, EPS, or PDF format. Individual figure files exceeding 10 MB must be uploaded separately. [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/international-business-review/publish/guide-for-authors) [Elsevier](https://www.elsevier.com/subject/next/guide-for-authors) Tables must be editable text (never images) and placed next to relevant text. A **CRediT author contribution statement** is required. [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/journal-of-world-business/publish/guide-for-authors)

Journal of World Business: APA 7th required, scope gate enforced

JWB shares many Elsevier defaults with IBR but imposes a critical additional requirement: **APA 7th edition citation style is explicitly mandated**. The guide directly references the *Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association, Seventh Edition (2020)*, ISBN 978-1-4338-3215-4*. [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/journal-of-world-business/publish/guide-for-authors) While the initial submission allows any consistent reference format [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/international-business-review/publish/guide-for-authors) (with APA applied at proof stage), authors targeting JWB should format in APA 7th from the start to avoid delays.

The abstract ceiling is more generous at **250 words** (unstructured), [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/journal-of-world-business/publish/guide-for-authors) and references cited within the abstract must be given in full. [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/international-review-of-economics-and-finance/publish/guide-for-authors) [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/journal-of-world-business/publish/guide-for-authors) Keywords are capped at **1–7**, [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/research-in-international-business-and-finance/publish/guide-for-authors) [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/journal-of-world-business/publish/guide-for-authors) the most restrictive upper bound of the three journals but also the most flexible lower bound (just one keyword is technically acceptable). Highlights are "encouraged" rather than required, following the same **3–5 bullet, 85-character-per-bullet format** as IBR, submitted as a separate file. [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/journal-of-world-business/publish/guide-for-authors)

JWB's **scope gate** is a common desk-rejection trigger that many authors overlook. The guide states that "submissions must have an explicit multinational, cross-border, or international comparative orientation." [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/journal-of-world-business/publish/guide-for-authors) [Elsevier Shop](https://shop.elsevier.com/journals/journal-of-world-business/1090-9516) Single-country studies are acceptable only if they "reflect some cross-border or

comparative dimensions, or explore and advance other issues affecting international business."

[ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/journal-of-world-business/publish/guide-for-authors) Authors should address this scope fit explicitly.

Anonymization rules mirror IBR: a **separate title page** with full author details and acknowledgments, and a clean anonymized manuscript. [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/research-in-international-business-and-finance/publish/guide-for-authors) [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/journal-of-world-business/publish/guide-for-authors) The guide is less granular than IBR on self-citation anonymization mechanics but equally firm on removing all identifying information from the manuscript body, figures, and tables.

For figures, JWB specifies the same resolution tiers as IBR (**300 / 500 / 1,000 dpi**) and adds explicit pixel-width requirements: minimum **1,063 pixels** for single-column and **2,244 pixels** for full-page-width images. [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/research-in-international-business-and-finance/publish/guide-for-authors) [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/journal-of-world-business/publish/guide-for-authors) Notably, **AI-generated artwork is prohibited** for graphical abstracts or any figures. [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/journal-of-business-research/publish/guide-for-authors) [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/journal-of-world-business/publish/guide-for-authors) Tables must be editable text with no vertical rules or shading, [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/journal-of-world-business/publish/guide-for-authors) and the guide specifically asks authors to "use tables sparingly."

The submission portal is **Editorial Manager**. File format requirements are identical to IBR: Word (.doc/.docx) or LaTeX in single-column layout, with PDF explicitly rejected as a source file. [ScienceDirect+2](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/research-in-international-business-and-finance/publish/guide-for-authors) A CRediT author contribution statement and funding disclosure are both required. [ScienceDirect](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/journal-of-world-business/publish/guide-for-authors) The cover letter is not explicitly mandated in the guide text, though Elsevier's general guidance recommends one.

Asia Pacific Journal of Management: the strictest format rules of the three

APJM, as a Springer journal, operates under a distinctly different formatting philosophy. Where the two Elsevier journals are relaxed about manuscript appearance, **APJM specifies concrete formatting details** and enforces a hard word limit.

The **10,000-word maximum is all-inclusive**: footnotes, references, tables, and figures all count toward the cap. [Springer](https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines) [springer](https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines) This is the only journal of the three with an explicitly stated word limit, and it is rigorously enforced. The abstract must be **150–250 words**

(unstructured), and **4–6 keywords** are required for indexing. [springer]
(<https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines>)

The reference style is **APA 7th edition**, with the guide encouraging authors to "include all authors up to 20; for larger groups, give the first 19 names followed by an ellipsis and the final author's name." DOIs should be formatted as full URL links (e.g., <https://doi.org/abc>). [springer]
(<https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines>) Unlike the Elsevier journals, APJM expects proper APA formatting from initial submission — there is no "any consistent style" grace period.

APJM is the only journal of the three that specifies **font and size**: "a normal, plain font (e.g., 10-point Times Roman)." [Springer](<https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines>) [springer]
(<https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines>) Double-spacing is not stated on the current guidelines page but is effectively required based on editorial guidance — a former editor-in-chief's published article warns that single-spaced submissions signal inattention to detail. [Springer]
(<https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s10490-011-9260-x>) Headings are limited to **three levels maximum**, [Springer](<https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines>) and footnotes (not endnotes) are required. [springer](<https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines>)

Highlights are not required and not mentioned in the APJM guidelines — this is a standard Springer convention. There is also no graphical abstract requirement.

The anonymization process follows double-blind conventions: a **separate title page** with all author information, affiliations, ORCID identifiers, acknowledgments, and a full declarations section (funding, competing interests, ethics approval, consent, data/code availability, author contributions). The manuscript file must be fully scrubbed. [springer](<https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines>) An important caveat: APJM **recently transitioned its submission system**, and some title-page information may now be entered directly into the system interface rather than uploaded as a separate document. [springer](<https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines>) Authors should follow on-screen instructions carefully.

Figure requirements differ from Elsevier's standards. APJM follows Springer's specifications: **1,200 dpi** for line art (higher than Elsevier's 1,000 dpi), **300 dpi** for halftones, and **600 dpi** for combination artwork. Preferred formats are EPS for vector graphics and TIFF for halftones. Lettering must use **Helvetica or Arial at 8–12 pt**, and all lines must be at least **0.1 mm wide**. [Springer]
(<https://link.springer.com/journal/11145/submission-guidelines>) [Springer]
(<https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines>) Color online publication is free, but print color requires an author contribution to costs. [springer]
(<https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines>)

A **data availability statement** is mandatory for all original research [springer]
(<https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines>) — the most stringent data policy among the three journals. [Springer](<https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines>) The submission portal is **Editorial Manager** (at editorialmanager.com/apjm), though Springer Nature is

actively migrating journals to its new **SNAPP platform**. APJM accepts Word (.docx/.doc) and LaTeX; [Springer](<https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines>) [springer] (<https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines>) Springer provides a general LaTeX template with an APA style option (`\sn-apa`) but no APJM-specific Word template.

Practical submission checklist across all three journals

Several patterns emerge that authors preparing manuscripts for any of these three outlets should internalize. First, **all three use double-blind review and require a separate title page** — failing to separate identifying information from the manuscript is a guaranteed formatting failure. Second, both JWB and APJM require **APA 7th edition** from the start, while IBR allows flexibility at initial submission but will apply its house style at proof.

The starkest divergence is on highlights: **mandatory at IBR**, encouraged at JWB, and irrelevant at APJM. Authors repurposing a manuscript across these journals must add or remove highlight files accordingly. Similarly, APJM's **10,000-word hard cap** requires significant discipline [Springer] (<https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines>) — an IBR or JWB manuscript that runs 12,000–13,000 words will need substantial trimming before APJM submission.

For figures, the safest approach across all three journals is to prepare artwork at **1,200 dpi** for line art, **600 dpi** for combinations, and **300 dpi** for photographs in TIFF or EPS format — this meets or exceeds every journal's requirements. Tables should always be editable text, never images, across all three.

Conclusion

The three journals cluster into two formatting ecosystems. **IBR and JWB share Elsevier's Editorial Manager infrastructure**, relaxed initial formatting, highlight requirements, and identical file-format rules — but diverge on abstract length (150 vs. 250 words), reference style strictness, and scope gatekeeping. **APJM operates under Springer's more prescriptive framework** with explicit font, word-limit, and data-availability requirements, no highlights, and a submission system in active transition. The highest-risk desk-rejection triggers are IBR's 25% similarity threshold, [ScienceDirect] (<https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/international-business-review/publish/guide-for-authors>) JWB's international scope requirement, and APJM's 10,000-word ceiling. [Springer] (<https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines>) [springer] (<https://link.springer.com/journal/10490/submission-guidelines>) Authors should verify all requirements directly on each journal's official guide page before submission, as guidelines — particularly APJM's during its platform migration — are subject to change.